

Identifying Phishing & Social Engineering Attacks

What is Phishing?

Phishing attack is used to get a sensitive data from the victim as the attacker send a message as a college or as a friend and try to get as much sensitive data as can, and then use this information to login victim email and bank account.

What is Social Engineering?

In social engineering, an attacker come to organization or make an interaction with you physically and trying to get some confidential information at this stage the attacker must be in the form of new employee , new friend or a repair person at this stage the attacker use their soft skills to get some confidential information like computers specifications and security of the system.

Warning Signs:

- Attacker replace a phishing link with the original one.
- Attacker must be asking do it fast its very urgent.
- Attached unexpected attachment with the phishing email.

Types of Attacks:

- Email phishing
- SMS phishing
- Social Engineering

Real-World Examples:

Here is an example of what we have seen here at Return Path:

Hey Neil, it's Michelle here, it has been a long time huh ? how're you doing ? how's your work with Return Path ? Is everything ok there ? Hey, can you believe it! I got married to Brian ! Yes I did. I tried to call but you did not answer. You have changed your number, haven't you? Just give me your current telephone number if you read this mail. It's really a pity that we did not see you in our wedding. I wanted to invite you so much. Well, here I'm sending you a few pics taken in our wedding:

<http://www.weddingphotos4u.net/Photos/Michelle/>

Let's keep in touch then.

Love,

Michelle & Brian

The URL above was in fact a fake, the target URL itself ended up at a different website hosting malware.

Prevention Tips:

- Verify email sender
- Don't open suspicious links
- Report to IT department and the security agency

Source Links:

- KrebsOnSecurity: <https://krebsonsecurity.com/2010/11/spear-phishing-attacks-snag-e-mail-marketers/>
- CISA Alert: https://www.cisa.gov/sites/default/files/2023-10/Phishing_Guidance_-_Stopping_the_Attack_Cycle_at_Phase_One_508c.pdf